

VICTOR SYROTA


SIKOR
SERVICE OF ISOLATION
OF CYBERNETIC
OBJECTS OF REALITY
ACCESS RESTRICTED

SIKOR

A PREQUEL NOVELLA

THE MAKING OF A SCAVENGER

BEFORE HE BECAME A LEGEND,
HE WAS JUST A SYSTEM ADMIN.

COFFEE.
SERVERS.
SOLUTIONS.



June 11, 2047

Waking up, Victor lay with his eyes closed for a few more seconds. He had long noticed this habit of his — not jumping out of bed right away, but letting his brain fully wake up.

"Good morning, Victor," a calm female voice sounded.

"Good morning, Marichka."

"You overslept by seven minutes compared to your usual time."

"Guess my body decided to take a bonus for hard work."

After a short pause, the voice replied: "I am taking that as a joke."

Victor smiled. Such conversations happened almost every morning. He couldn't even remember the last time he woke up without Marichka's voice.

While he was washing up, the coffee maker turned on in the kitchen. His phone was on the table. Two messages. Both from his mom.

"Don't forget that today is at six." "And don't buy anything. That's an order."

"Marichka, remind me to buy flowers."

"At 5:20 PM. This will allow you not to alter your route."

"Thanks."

"You're welcome."

The phone rang.

"Hi, Mom."

"Are you up already?"

"Just woke up."

"Did Marichka wake you?"

"As always."

"Give her my thanks."

Victor smiled. "Hear that, Marichka? You got a thank you."

"Gratitude received."

His mother laughed. "I still don't understand why you gave a home assistant a woman's name."

"Because I like it better this way."

"An ironclad argument, of course."

Victor put the phone in his pocket and finished his coffee.

"Is it going to rain today?" he asked, putting on his jacket.

"The probability of precipitation is four percent."

"So I don't need to take an umbrella."

"Unless the forecast changes."

"Gotta love optimists."

"I am not an optimist. I work with statistics."

He smiled. "See you tonight, Marichka."

This time, the answer didn't come immediately.

"Have a good day, Victor."

He closed the door and, as always, paid no attention to that short pause.

The server room greeted him with the usual hum of cooling fans. This was the sound Victor loved most in his work. If the servers are humming evenly, it means everything is working.

"Hey," Serhiy called out, peeking from behind a rack. "Just the guy I was looking for."

"Did something crash already?"

"Not yet. But it definitely will if you don't take a look."

"Optimist."

"I'm a sysadmin. Those are different things."

They laughed. Serhiy handed him a tablet.

"After the night update, one of the controllers started acting up."

Victor silently reviewed the event logs for a few minutes.

"It's not the controller."

"Then what?"

"A driver."

"You sure?"

"Almost."

"And the rest?"

"We'll leave one percent for surprises."

Half an hour later, the server was running again without a single error.

"This is exactly why I don't like you," Serhiy grumbled.

"Because I find the problem quickly?"

"Because after you, it looks obvious."

Victor just shrugged. He had stopped explaining long ago that it wasn't about talent. He just loved understanding how everything worked. Maybe that was why the sysadmin job never seemed boring to him. Every malfunction was a puzzle. And every puzzle had a solution.

There were a few minutes left until the end of the workday when his phone vibrated quietly. A message appeared on the screen.

Marichka *Reminder: 5:20 PM. Buy flowers.*

Victor smiled and touched the microphone icon.

"Marichka, you wouldn't have let me rest even without this reminder."

The reply came almost immediately. "The probability that you would forget to buy flowers was estimated at seventy-three percent."

"I don't even want to know where you get those numbers."

"They are based on previous observations."

"Alright, you convinced me."

Victor put the phone in his pocket, shut down his computer, and left the server room.

The kitchen smelled of fresh pastries.

"Wash your hands," his mother's voice drifted in. "And don't even think about arguing."

"Already washing."

"Good."

His father winked. "See? Thirty-five years of marriage, and I still follow commands."

"And rightly so," his mother replied without turning around.

Victor laughed.

It felt homey and cozy at the table. Nothing festive. A regular dinner, which his mother, as always, called "modest". Although the table could barely hold all that "modesty".

"Mom, you said there would be almost no guests."

"And there won't be."

"But there's enough food for a wedding."

"That's different."

His father coughed quietly. "Don't argue. This is a question without correct answers."

"I figured that out a long time ago."

His mother placed a plate in front of her son. "Eat while it's hot."

For a few minutes, they talked about everyday things. About the neighbors. About work. About the fact that the old apricot tree had borne so much fruit this year, as if it decided to make up for all the previous years.

No one was in a rush. Such evenings were rare. That was exactly why Victor loved them.

When the tea was already poured into cups, his father pushed back his chair.

"Well, let's go."

"Already?"

"What are we waiting for?"

His mother just shook her head. "Here it starts."

"What starts?" Victor smiled.

"Two grown men will go to the workshop, and I'll spend another hour listening to why one piece of iron is fundamentally different from another piece of iron."

"Not true," his father took offense. "Not an hour."

"An hour and a half," Victor added.

They exchanged looks and laughed simultaneously.

"Just go," his mother waved her hand. "But you better be back in ten minutes. The cake isn't going to eat itself."

"Hear that?" his father said. "We have exactly ten minutes."

"It's a challenge."

"Exactly."

The workshop began right behind the garage. Victor hadn't been here in a few months. Everything remained almost the same. The workbench by the window. The shelves with boxes on which his father had handwritten many years ago: "Resistors," "Fasteners," "Cables". Although after a couple of decades, there was just random stuff lying in them.

"Here."

His father took a small wooden box down from the shelf and carefully placed it on the table.

"Is this your secret project?"

"Open it."

Inside lay an old mechanical clock. Ordinary. With a worn brass case and slightly scratched glass.

"Remember it?"

Victor looked closer. "It's..."

"Grandpa's."

He carefully took the clock in his hands. "I thought it stopped working a long time ago."

"It had."

His father smiled. "But now it works."

He pressed a small lever. The mechanism clicked quietly. A moment later, a steady ticking could be heard.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

It became so quiet in the workshop that this sound filled the entire space.

"Beautiful, isn't it?"

Victor nodded silently.

"You know why I don't like throwing old things away?"

"Because you're stubborn?"

His father laughed. "That too."

He carefully took the clock back. "It's just that any object was created by a human. As long as it can be fixed, its life hasn't ended."

Victor ran his finger over the old case.

"Mom!" his father called out. "We made it in ten minutes!"

"I don't believe it!" a voice came from the house.

"Check for yourself."

They looked at each other and burst out laughing. His father put the clock back in the box.

"Someday it will be yours."

"Let it be yours for a while longer."

"Alright. But don't hide it too far. I might want to take it apart again."

Over cake, they talked about trivial things. His father argued with his mother about whether they needed to replace the old fence. His mother promised yet again to throw out half the junk from the workshop. His father promised yet again not to let her do it.

When Victor was getting ready to go home, his mother wrapped up a few pieces of pie for him.

"Mom, I don't live in a dorm anymore."

"I know."

"Then why?"

"Because you're my son."

Arguing was pointless.

June 12, 2047

Victor woke up on his own. He lay there for a few more seconds without opening his eyes.

It was quiet. Unusually quiet.

Marichka never forgot to wish him a good morning. He opened his eyes and looked at the clock.

8:23 AM.

"Damn..."

He overslept.

"Marichka!"

Silence. He sat up in bed.

"Marichka, what happened?"

No answer.

It didn't smell like coffee in the kitchen. The blinds were still down. Even the AC was silent.

Victor quickly picked up his phone. The screen lit up. But...

No messages. No network. No time.

An unfamiliar system error icon was blinking in the top corner.

"What the..."

He pressed the call button. Nothing. Rebooted the phone. Nothing. Opened the smart home app. Empty. Like it never existed.

Now he felt truly anxious. Victor hurriedly got dressed and ran out of the apartment.

There were already people in the hallway. Someone was fruitlessly pressing the elevator button. Someone was talking on the phone, not understanding why there wasn't even a signal.

Outside, it was even worse.

A driverless bus was stalled in the middle of the road. Behind it, cars were stopping one by one. Dozens of drones hovered in the sky. A few seconds later, they started falling. First one. Then a second. Then several at once. The sounds of breaking glass came from different directions. People looked around, still not grasping what was happening.

And then someone screamed.

And panic rolled through the city. The street was buzzing. Not from sirens yet. From human voices.

"It's not working!" "Mine neither!" "Call the cops!" "I can't get through!"

Someone nervously slammed their palm against the door of their own car. Someone repeatedly pressed the start button. All in vain.

The driverless bus stood in the middle of the intersection with its doors open. Passengers were exiting in silence. No one understood what to do next.

Victor absentmindedly took out his phone. No network. He tried dialing his mother. Empty. His father. Still nothing. His finger reached for the contact "Marichka" on its own.

The screen lit up for a moment. Then a short message appeared: "Subscriber unavailable."

Victor smiled bitterly. As if she could be a subscriber.

It took him almost an hour to get to the office. Most of the traffic lights were already out. Traffic jams formed at the intersections. People honked at each other, although it didn't change anything.

A crowd had already gathered near the entrance to the office building.

"Open up!" "My kid is inside!" "The doors won't open!"

The glass doors remained locked. The electronic locks didn't respond. Someone was already looking for a crowbar. Someone was trying to break the glass.

Victor silently walked around the building. The service entrance. A mechanical lock. Luckily. He still had the key.

A minute later, he was standing in the server room.

Silence.

It had never been this quiet here. No hum of cooling fans. No blinking indicators. Only rows of black server cabinets.

Victor pressed the emergency start button. Nothing. Checked the main breaker. Turned on. UPS. Dead.

He opened one of the server cabinets. Hard drives, processors, memory... Everything was in place. And at the same time... As if it no longer existed.

A familiar voice came from the doorway.

"Vitya..."

It was Serhiy. Pale.

"It's not just us."

Victor looked at him silently.

"I went to the neighboring data center. Same thing there. The servers are... dead. All of them. No exceptions."

Victor slowly sat down on the floor, leaning his back against a server cabinet. For the first time in many years, he didn't know what to do. Because if not a single server was working... ...there was no way to fix it anymore.

Days passed. Then weeks. Then months.

The world Victor had known his whole life disappeared. The familiar sounds of the city disappeared. Work disappeared. Plans disappeared.

During this time, he lost almost everything that was important to him. When he returned home, no one was waiting for him anymore. Only silence.

At first, it scared him. Then it became familiar. But he never could accept it.

Sometimes Victor sat for hours in front of the powered-down smart home control panel. The dark screen remained silent. Marichka didn't answer anymore.

Only a year had passed. And he almost couldn't remember her voice. He remembered certain words. Intonation. The habit of wishing him a good day. But the voice itself was slowly erasing from his memory. And that terrified him.

If memory could so easily take away even a voice... What would be left in another ten years?

One evening, Victor locked his apartment and walked through the city without any destination. Past abandoned offices. Past dark administrative buildings. Past closed data centers. He looked at them and couldn't shake one thought.

Did all this really disappear forever? Is there really not a single trace left anywhere of the world they had built over decades?

The next day he returned there with a backpack. Inside lay a flashlight, screwdrivers, a multimeter, and a few empty drives.

That's exactly how it all started.

Ten years passed...

The city aged along with the people who stayed in it. Glass facades became covered with cracks. Grass pushed through the asphalt. Signs that once shone day and night had long since gone dark. In place of office districts now stood silent concrete boxes with blown-out windows.

Data centers, once the heart of the digital world, turned into cold ruins. Most people steered clear of them. Victor did not.

He went almost every day to where data used to live. Wandered through empty server rooms. Carefully stepped over overturned server cabinets. Opened every door that could still be opened. Kicked up dust from the floor, clearing the rubble.

Sometimes he found an old hard drive. Sometimes a server board. Sometimes just a mangled piece of metal.

He took it all. Carried it home. Stacked it along the walls, on shelves, in boxes. Not knowing why himself. Perhaps because he couldn't come to terms with the idea that all that world had vanished without a trace.

Over these ten years, he had changed a lot. Gray hair touched his temples. Deep wrinkles appeared on his face. His movements became slower and more careful. He almost stopped smiling.

But he learned to notice things that others passed by with indifference. A broken server. A damaged drive. A forgotten network switch. To most, it was junk. To him, it was another story that deserved a chance.

Sometimes he caught himself thinking that he had long stopped looking for hardware. He was looking for proof that that world had ever really existed. That he hadn't made it up. That one morning, a familiar voice really had woken him up.

But with each passing year, even that memory became more and more phantom. And yet, the next day he would put the flashlight, multimeter, and screwdrivers back in his backpack. And set out to search again.

That day everything was the same as always.

Victor walked slowly through familiar streets, peering intently into abandoned buildings. He had been to some of them before. Into others, he entered for the first time. Sometimes he found something interesting. More frequently, he didn't.

Today was no different from hundreds of previous days. Another closed office. Another empty server room. Another box of old cables that nobody needed anymore.

He was about to move on when he suddenly stopped.

At the end of the building, almost completely hidden by thick bushes, a narrow concrete descent could be seen.

Victor frowned. "Strange..."

Most office buildings didn't have basements like that.

He pushed aside the dry branches. Down below stood massive metal doors. Rusty. Scratched. Without a single inscription.

But something made him freeze.

Thick cable entries were still visible in the wall next to the doors. Once, dozens of fiber-optic trunk lines ran through them. They didn't make things like that for a regular basement.

Victor lowered his backpack to the ground. Ran his palm over the cold metal. Pulled the handle. The door wouldn't budge.

He pushed with his shoulder. Somewhere deep inside, the rusted mechanism groaned dully.

The doors slowly opened. A cold, stale smell wafted out from the darkness to meet him.

Victor turned on his flashlight. Carefully crossed the threshold. And took a step inside...

This is only the beginning of the story...

Beyond those rusted doors, Victor will discover something that will change not only his life, but the fate of the entire world.

Continue the journey in the novel *Neon Heart*.

<https://www.amazon.com/dp/B0FPGHMR5R>